

A Few Words
occasioned by
Prof. Scharling's Apology
for
Dr. Martensen's Dogmatics

by
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Copenhagen.

University Bookseller C. A. *Reitzel*.

Printed by Royal Court Printer Bianco Luno.

1850.

Translated from the Danish

Μιλήσιοι ἄζύνετοι μέν οὐκ εἰσί· δρῶσι δὲ, οἷα περ οἱ ἄζύνετοι.

Demodacus.

[The Milesians are not stupid, but they act just as the stupid do.]

In "Nyt theologisk Tidsskrift" (vol. 1, no. 2, pp. 348–375) His Reverence Dr. theol. [3] Prof. C. E. Scharling has — remarkably enough! — appeared as apologist for Dr. Martensen's dogmatics.

That so energetic a step on Prof. Scharling's part has come somewhat unexpectedly to me and has also put me in great embarrassment, I will not conceal. For a sharp scientific rejoinder from Dr. Martensen himself I have long been prepared, but for an Apology from Prof. Scharling, no, that I confess, for so genial an Apology I was not prepared at all.

Why I call the Scharlingian Apology *genial* is easy to explain. A scientific defense holds strictly to the opponent's objections and grounds; but such formal considerations are naturally of subordinate importance in an Apology whose entire probative force can be reduced to the categories: goodwill and ill will, approval and disapproval, praise and blame.

Where Prof. Scharling at present has his scientific standpoint, and whether he has one at all, I shall not be able to decide; on the other hand, from the present document [4] it is by no means difficult to state his apologetic standpoint: Prof. Scharling is at the present time — genially praising Prof. Martensen, genially censuring his opponents. What Prof. Scharling now actually *thinks* about the relation of "faith" to "knowledge", about the relation of religion to philosophy, of Christianity to theology, the little acuteness that was granted me will not be able to discover from his genial Apology; what I can discover without effort, on the other hand, and what the theological professor has undeniably also succeeded in presenting with rare theological clarity, is the turning point, surely by no means unimportant for "theological science" either, that His Reverence has become angry with Mr. Stilling and me.

Thus the first faculty-sanctioned yield of the first faculty-sanctioned Apology for our newest literature's first faculty-sanctioned dogmatics is to be expressed and held fast in the proposition, as weighty as it is momentous: *Professor Scharling has become angry with Mr. Stilling and Professor Nielsen.*

That on this serious and solemn occasion I name Mr. Stilling first has its ground in modesty, and is done solely for politeness' sake; for according to the unequal, though surely fair, distribution of the anger, the first place properly belongs to me. The matter is this: with Mr. Stilling Professor Scharling is angry for one reason only, namely that Mr. Stilling has permitted himself to write against Dr. Martensen; with me, on the other hand, His Reverence is angry for two reasons, for I have not only been so bold as to write against Dr. Martensen, but had besides previously been so foolhardy as to [5]

write a good deal against “the theological mediocrities.”^{*)}

There is, then, in the genial Apology a common chastisement that befalls us both. We have both grievously sinned against theological science by “the unpleasant surprise” that our “more detailed assessments” of “the Christian Dogmatics” have prepared for Dr. Martensen; “the scornful irony, the teasing mockery with which the verdict of rejection is accompanied, the cruel pleasure with which we” — that I too may express myself genially — “shoot off the arrows of irony” at the poor “celebrated” author, “seem (p. 351) unable to exclude the supposition that motives other than the pure zeal for truth appealed to have made themselves felt in the composition of our critiques”; in short: we are both chastised, and thoroughly, for we have both been naughty.

But besides the common theological chastisement thus awarded to us both, Prof. Scharling's apologetic geniality has yet another chastisement, a surplus, an extra helping of chastisement, which is awarded to me in particular. Although we are, as said, both naughty, Mr. Stilling is nevertheless not nearly so naughty as I. Admittedly Mr. Stilling is violent — “perhaps even the most violent” — but notwithstanding (cf. Anm. p. 360) “Mr. Stilling's writing nevertheless bears, alongside personal touchiness, the stamp of a subjective conviction that awakens the reader to seriousness and sympathy”... It is otherwise with me! “It is otherwise with Prof. Nielsen. His [6] presentation calls forth the impression as if he might well make the offer: “If you will now take my opinion, then I will in turn defend your opinion”... — Alas, what shall I answer? It would perhaps be better if I did not answer at all, but kept silent, and bowed in all deference to the theological chastisement! for, seriously speaking, what shall I answer? With me things are going to the extreme; to my astonishment and most unpleasant surprise I now learn that I stand at the edge of two extremes, two dreadful extremes, whose names I dare not even mention, but must leave the reader to discover from Prof. Scharling's description.

The first extreme is described (p. 364 Anm.) thus: “He (Prof. N.) does not readily name the theologians without some scornful epithet or other (school theologians, middle-way theologians, &c.); everything stupid and wrong that theologians may have deserved and not deserved, he gathers into features of the caricatures with which he seeks to make his theological opponents martyrs of ridicule. This, by the way, is connected with a strange illusion about the esteem which he thinks theologians, especially theological doctors and professors, enjoy. Therefore he persecutes these

^{*)}Cf. “The Gospel-Faith and the Modern Consciousness”.

with the same bitterness and satire as Voltaire (sic!) in his time the priests."

The second, still far more questionable extreme is described thus: after Mr. Stilling's proposition *quamvis absurdum sit, credo* has been touched on provisionally, it says in the text (p. 364): "nevertheless there must underlie the latter declaration, if it is not to be dismissed out of hand as excluding all further rational deliberation, the notion that the Christian dogmas, however unreasonable they may present themselves to the subject, nevertheless have an objectively valid and eternal truth, which it is [7] only not possible, on account of hindrances or limitations in the subject" (—NB—) "to cognize in a given state." Upon this psychological explanation there now follows the note, and the note one must by no means skip, for the note is the best part, for the note is even more genial than the text, for in the note lies the point, for in the note Professor Scharling says: "Whether this (— namely what is adduced about Mr. Stilling's proposition —) should, however, be Prof. Nielsen's opinion, I do not know; for he finds Stilling's cited formula still too ambiguous, and wants it interpreted in the proposition: *credo, quia absurdum est*. Thus there might here have come about in actuality what J. P. Lange (Christl. Dogmatik, 1849, 1ster Th. p. 409) has recently posited as a *possibility*, "daß am Ende auch noch ein Philosoph kommen könnte, der das Denken oder das Bewustseyn selbst ebenfalls für eine Illusion erklären wollte. Was wäre nun da anzufangen? Man mußte ihn mit dem Zugeständniß, daß sein eignes Bewustseyn in Taumel gerathen sein könne, nach Hause schicken."

Nach Hause! so then: nach Hause! yes, let it rest there: nach Hause!

When with my "Gospel-Faith" and my "examining review" I advanced against a theological science that is surely very considerable in the literature, but in my conviction wholly untenable, I was even then not prepared for so few possibilities; but that this *possibility*, this here *possibility* of which Prof. Scharling speaks, should be just so near to "having come about in actuality", no, that I confess, for that I was not at all prepared: that is indeed also a "surprising" stratagem of the genial Apology. [8]

At this stratagem I and my writings must then feel roughly like the council of war in a middling fortress that is unexpectedly taken by surprise by a strong and cunning enemy; one foresees clearly that resistance is futile, and yet, since it is after all not an open town, but in all "mediocrity" a fortress, one feels that one must, at least for honor's sake, do something. So, yes precisely so, it now goes with me in this apologetic surprise attack. Prof. Scharling throws down the gauntlet to believing speculation: I feel that I must do something, and foresee nevertheless that nothing can come of it.

That I now really, despite all my “irritability”, must have a certain reason to be cautious with Prof. Scharling’s literary verdicts, His Reverence himself will be able to testify when he thinks back. Some years ago, it was just at the time when — as His Rev. himself says p. 352 — “the so-called speculative theology here in this country enjoyed an esteem whose luster had already begun to fade in its original home,” I published a commentary on Paul’s Epistle to the Romans, composed not in a strictly Hegelian but in a speculative-theological spirit. This commentary at once had the misfortune to attract Prof. Scharling’s attention, for which reason he then also, after his genial custom, found himself entitled to deliver a literary verdict, so as at the same time to set me a little to rights.

[9] Had I then felt a calling to engage with Prof. Scharling, the occasion would have been as favorable as possible. “In those days” — says His Rev. himself p. 353 — “a harsh judgment generally fell upon all men of science who would not or could not put themselves in immediate relation to the prevailing system”; so then: in those days, when the reasoners’ objection to speculative cognition was “dismissed with a stern rebuke for spiritual narrowness and unfamiliarity with the essence of philosophy”, in those days it was precisely that Prof. Scharling dispatched my attempt on the Epistle to the Romans^{*)}, and in those days I would then also, given my exceedingly great “irritability”, have had the finest opportunity to be — a little naughty toward Prof. Scharling.

Why then, since my “irritability” is after all so excessive, did I neglect the favorable opportunity, and bow in modest silence under the genial chastisement? — Dear reader, what shall I answer? If I answer that I did it because I felt a certain diffidence about attacking a man who shortly before had been my teacher: then I will hardly be believed; for His Reverence already at that time accused me of ironizing presumption. If I answer that I did it because I preferred to spare a man who evidently by a pure mistake had come to deliver his verdict in a matter that concerned theological speculation: then I will hardly be believed either; for I am after all once and for all suspected of “other motives”. Well, then I will answer what is true, and give an answer that Prof. Scharling will surely believe better than any other; I will then answer him and say it straight out: I did it out of fear.

[10] What instilled this fear in me was by no means the sharpness of the Scharlingian objections (for they lacked all sharpness), nor the weight of the Scharlingian grounds (for they lacked all weight), but a fatal circumstance, namely that Prof. Scharling in my

^{*)}Tidsskrift for Litteratur og Kritik, ed. F. C. Petersen. 1842. vol. 1. p. 210.

youthful attempt could find no — “spirit” at all. Yes, it was precisely this circumstance that already at that time paralyzed my strength, and struck into me a terror I have not since that time got over.

For a more thorough appreciation of my great embarrassment I can perhaps best lead the reader by a small detour.

Before one engages in a literary dispute at all, one should sensibly look about to see whom one is going to deal with, and, as far as possible, seek to sound out the polemical forces. As regards scientific polemic in particular, it seems to me as if authors could best be divided into the following three classes: 1) the authors who, in the form of genius and of freedom, are sure of principle and idea; 2) the authors who recognize the principle in the form of a fundamental tenet, and therefore must bow to regular consistency; 3) the authors who do not step aside for any principle, since in their literary geniality they do not really know what a principle is.

That authors of the first rank are dangerous polemicists, especially when they are also gifted with so witty an imagination that they can even hide the gravity of the serious in the lightness of jest, goes without saying. I name here Mr. Kierkegaard and Prof. Heiberg, for by naming these names I relieve the reader and myself of a prosaic description of the higher polemic.

To polemicists of the second class belong all capable and reliable men of science, [11] who seek their strength directly in proofs and grounds; these authors are as a rule bound to the prosaic form of formal seriousness, and are therefore also best known under the name of “the serious authors”.

To the polemicists of No. 3 belong all principle-free, or rather: unprincipled, yet serious, indefatigable and learned writers, all worthy members of the worthy family *Wagner*^{*)}, who in so worthy a manner advance science in all directions and adorn literature in all countries. When an author of this kinship makes as if to engage in a literary dispute, especially in a dialectical dispute over principle, one must be careful, very careful, for this kind of folk is extremely dangerous. — With the polemicists of the first rank one still gets off reasonably well, provided one otherwise has a good cause and a sound thought (even if one loses, the loss is always a gain); but woe to him who must defend himself with a principle against those who are not hit by any principle; woe to him who must defend the unity of a thought against those who appropriate all manner of thoughts and all sorts of ideas, and precisely thereby prove in the finest way “that the spiritual nature of human beings constitutes a unity”; yes,

^{*)}Cf. Goethe's Faust.

woe to him who falls into the hands of a polemicist of No. 3, for — with the Wagner family there is no getting along.

The reader surely already senses my embarrassment. — Under which rubric Prof. S. will place me is easy to see from the ominous remark: “nach Hause,” for me, on [12] the other hand, it is by no means easy to see under which rubric I am in this matter to place Professor Scharling. To put him among the polemicists of the first rank will hardly do (now of course, if someone else wants to do it, I shall say nothing against it, but — I dare not). To place His Reverence under No. 3 will do still less; that would indeed be a bloody insult to a man who is not only a member of the theological faculty, but, if I remember rightly, even a member of the Society of Sciences. My serious endeavor must therefore aim at getting him placed in a class with the “serious men of science” under rubric No. 2; but how thankless this endeavor is, and how little hope I can have this time of bringing it to any favorable result, the expert will easily be able to see from a cursory reading of his genial Apology.

As one of the main features that especially characterize this Apology, and by which Prof. Scharling together with his theological journal seems especially to find himself in — “a steady progress”, I must here emphasize the literary unceremoniousness, an interesting main feature that is likewise connected with the genial.

“It is strange,” says Prof. Scharling, as he (p. 355) mentions Mr. Kierkegaard, “that no one has yet made this author’s writings the object of a more detailed analysis, which they both deserve in themselves, and for which there seems to be special occasion in the approval they have won among readers of the most different levels of education.” Since I am now wholly in agreement with Prof. Scharling in this, it seems to me for precisely that reason most “strange” that His Rev. has been able with so [13] much unceremoniousness to engage in so rather dismissive an assessment of these writings, without there being in this assessment the slightest trace that His Reverence himself has deigned to give them even a cursory, let alone a more detailed, analysis.

That Prof. Scharling has not deigned to give Mr. Kierkegaard’s books any analysis at all can be seen at once from the very first lines, in which he begins to review their form. There is hardly any bright student who does not already know that the Kierkegaardian writings, as regards form, divide into two main classes, and that each writing in each of these classes again has a form that is, in its kind, infinitely individualized, carefully articulated and nuanced down to the finest details. This difference of form, however, does not bother Prof. Scharling. Without troubling himself about some otherwise unusual transformations, His Rev. without ceremony

lumps all the books into one heap, and then continues in genial unceremoniousness to speak of “the formless prolixity, the irony that jests both in season and out of season, the forced hunt for paradoxes and antitheses, and the loquacity, witty perhaps, yet often tiring, that seems to prevent the author, despite his astonishing productivity, from bringing his reflections to any satisfactory conclusion.” With this conclusive conception of the Kierkegaardian form (a conception one has probably heard before from “busy people” in town) it is then also no doubt connected that Mr. Kierkegaard’s dialectic — strangely enough! — in Prof. Scharling (p. 358) “leaves a feeling as if his presentation were not really in earnest, but only an exercise in the higher gymnastics of the spirit.”*)

However, about form, and in particular about inwardness’s indirect form of communication in doubly reflected categories, I, who myself give such hard offense against form, am unworthy to take issue with Prof. Scharling, whose tasteful journal not only tastes form, but also tastes of form; a more detailed discussion of form would besides be out of place here, and lead us too far away from apologetic geniality. On the other hand I would — even if on this occasion I should give a little offense against form — yet most heartily like to give Prof. Scharling the well-meant advice never again to occupy himself with evaluating or criticizing the things he has not yet properly understood, and to that end draw his attention to some points in which his literary unceremoniousness seems to be of such a nature that it cannot even be excused by geniality. [14]

When Prof. Scharling (p. 368) evaluates Mr. Kierkegaard’s polemic against “the system”, he expresses himself in such a way that anyone not otherwise more closely informed must necessarily assume that Mr. Kierkegaard gradually strayed from the justified standpoint with which he began, and ended in an evident one-sidedness. Thus it says: “So long as Mr. Kierkegaard’s polemic confined itself to disputing that the system was capable of taking the place of faith... — then it was within its rights, and one followed it with approval and interest. But the more it aimed at removing faith and knowledge from each other, the more it was led over into the same one-sidedness [15] that it so vigorously combated... Therefore the continued polemic too, despite many a brilliant flash of thought, could not properly hit its object, the more it left the more abstract regions and entered into the given historical circumstances.”

*)A “more detailed analysis” of one of the pseudonyms (e.g. of Johannes Climacus) would, if it could only succeed reasonably well, certainly furnish strong contributions to answering the question: *What is seriousness?*

See, thus Mr. Kierkegaard's "astonishing productivity" is now dispatched at one stroke by Prof. Scharling. What impression must such an assessment now make? — On a wholly naive and credulous reader the assessment must presumably make the impression that Mr. Kierkegaard is here placed before a higher tribunal, that the theological-scientific superiority, which has long kept a watchful eye on his manifold "dialectical turns", now finally, when it seems to be going too far, at last breaks its silence and directs the restless "genius" back within the proper bounds. On me, however, the assessment makes a different impression, for on me it makes the impression as if the whole thing might perhaps be loose talk. The paradox of faith put forward by "Johannes Climacus" is after all essentially the very same paradox as the one that breathes in "*Fear and Trembling*". That the mood, the form and the development must be different is self-evident, since Johannes *de silentio* expectorates in "*dialectical lyric*", whereas Johannes Climacus on the other hand delivers an "*existential contribution*".

I state this assertion without circumlocution, not only because I think I am sure of my case, but especially because it is really Prof. Scharling on whom, as regards the denial, one may rightly lay the *onus probandi*. If, then, Prof. Scharling will stand by his word, and can clearly prove to me that Mr. K. has in the said writings changed [16] standpoint, that the paradox posed by Johannes *de silentio* is an entirely different one and in an entirely different relation to the *Absurdum* than the one posed by Johannes Climacus^{*)}; then, yes then, I shall not only be willing in all geniality to let someone "nach Hause schicken" me, but even into the bargain make amends to the "Apologetics" and gild "the critical introduction".

Since, however, it might easily happen that Prof. S. would remain in debt for the proof, and precisely thereby come to prove a little more than he actually wanted, I shall, for the sake of this case, not omit here to adduce something which at least in my eyes speaks considerably in his excuse. When His Rev. read through the "more detailed assessments" of Dr. Martensen's dogmatics, it no doubt happened to him that on behalf of "dogmatics" as well as of "theology" as a whole he felt most unpleasantly affected. In his worried mood he has then by an entirely natural association of ideas come to think first of Mr. Kierkegaard's paradox, then of my paradox, then of Mr. Stilling's paradox, thereafter by a likewise entirely natural association of ideas of

^{*)}For that Johannes *de silentio* speaks of Abraham's faith, Johannes Climacus on the other hand of Christian faith, makes no difference here, where the point is precisely to demonstrate the sphere of faith.

"Proudhon", "Max Stirner", yes, of Proudhon's and Max Stirner's "consorts" together with the remaining "vain mediocrities" (*les médiocrités ambitieuses*), who "increase the confusion by each casting his paradox out into the world"; in so worried a moment it has then seemed to him as if he saw Pandora's open box and saw distinctly that the box was full of — nothing but paradoxes; nor in so worried a moment was it easy for [17] His Rev. to make sense of the paradoxes, but all paradoxes, Christian, un-Christian, socialist, communist, Danish, French, German, Spanish, in short: all the world's real and unreal paradoxes have shown themselves to him in such multiplicity and have strayed so among one another that in the end it was not at all possible for him to tell which was which.

A main feature that likewise characterizes the Scharlingian Apology is a certain literary forgetfulness, a genial forgetfulness, which in several points betrays that the Right Reverend author surely cannot always have the most faithful memory. Why Prof. Scharling is not exactly any great patron of philosophical speculation, he himself confesses, and I thus need not explain the reason to him further; but that Prof. Scharling (if he has not otherwise quietly changed his earlier opinion) is not any particular patron of theological speculation either, I could even prove to him rather easily, if only I dared rely a little on his literary memory.

The view of the relation between faith and knowledge that underlies Dr. Martensen's dogmatics is certainly the same view as the one that underlies my exposition of Paul's Epistle to the Romans¹⁾.

That Prof. Scharling must, however, have forgotten this little circumstance is clear [18] enough from the words with which he (p. 371) meets the objections of criticism to the great proposition that the dogmatician is "*at once the organ of his science and of his church.*" Thus it says: "But every such view that recognizes in historical development something relative and mobile is rejected by a criticism which, while it reproaches others for having remained standing at the standpoint once taken, has not itself broken loose from its former standpoint, in the respect that it has retained from it just as much the abstract conception of "absolute knowledge", "objective certainty", "coherent cognition", as the notion of Christian faith either as a closed sum of certain

¹⁾By this, however, I by no means wish to have asserted that my form of exposition should be as classical as Dr. Martensen's (I am after all no "Genius"), nor in that youthful attempt was I able to work together quite so many heterogeneous elements as Dr. Martensen has done with so much plastic power in the finished work, in which "a mystical breath of life exercises a secretly captivating power over the unbiased reader". What I assert is only this, that the "fundamental view" is essentially the same, and I abide by this assertion of mine until I see a little proof of the opposite.

unalterable doctrines or as a wholly unclear and indeterminable feeling". — If Prof. Scharling, when he wrote down these remarkable lines, had only stopped to recollect a little, and called to mind the concept of "absolute knowledge", "objective certainty", "coherent cognition" that I have, e.g., developed in my propaedeutic logic, *item* the theological principle of cognition that runs through my Epistle to the Romans, His Rev. would certainly have struck out the whole passage, as not fitting me at all, although it is precisely I who attacked that great proposition of Dr. Martensen's. For should it [19] be true, what Prof. Scharling asserts, that I now have a wholly abstract conception of "absolute knowledge", "objective certainty", "coherent cognition", then it must at least be untrue, what Prof. Scharling nevertheless in the same breath likewise asserts, that in this respect I have not been able to break loose from my former standpoint, for in the two writings cited my conception of "absolute knowledge" and "objective certainty" is after all not so entirely abstract; but there is, once and for all, a fatality about literary forgetfulness!

When Prof. Scharling reviewed my exposition of the Epistle to the Romans, the spirit in theological speculation was to him still a foreign and unknown quantity, and therefore he — to my astonishment — could not find the spirit either. Now, on the other hand, when Dr. Martensen "has with his usual clarity expressed himself in the introduction to his dogmatics in a manner which on the whole will be found as appealing as it is satisfying by anyone who has not given up the conviction that the spiritual nature of man constitutes a unity", now Prof. Scharling suddenly catches sight of the spirit, acknowledges the principle, and then appears in all geniality as apologist for theological speculation.

But how shall I now explain this strange phenomenon to myself? I by no means assume that Prof. Scharling intentionally wanted to be partial or to do me wrong; rather I believe I have discovered a point of view from which the whole thing can be explained in a manner as natural as it is genial. The point lies in what His Rev. calls "the constellation of spiritual movements". As little as Prof. Scharling can ever be [20] assumed to have been partial against "speculation", so little can he yet be assumed to be partial against "the paradox". Prof. Scharling surely at bottom likes "the paradox" just as much as "speculation", and only wishes that they would nicely know how to value that, and be prettily reconciled with each other. When Prof. Scharling, therefore, at present speaks a little harshly to "the paradox" and expresses himself a little differently about "speculation" than he formerly did, the cause of this is hardly to be sought in any essential change in Prof. Scharling's "fundamental view"; but

“here a more natural and worthier explanation at once offers itself, if we go back in time, and attend to the difference in the constellation of spiritual movements.”

In those days, when the speculation of faith was so “haughty”, and looked down so superciliously on the “critical introduction”, in those days when there generally fell “a harsh judgment on all men of science and writers who would not or could not” — occupy themselves with speculation, in those days Prof. Scharling was but little pleased with the whole business of speculation, whether for that matter it was philosophical or theological. Not without a certain inner satisfaction His Rev. then greeted the days when a polemic as justified as it was irresistible rose up against the troublesome system, and made “speculation” comic; to that extent Prof. S. then followed “the paradox” with “approval and interest” — But then came in turn the days when “speculation” crept to the cross, and almost on the verge of tears over “the arbitrariness of the paradox” poured out its grief into the feeling bosom of “the critical introduction”; and those days are presumably more or less these days, and in these days Prof. Scharling has then also felt that it is finally going too far, and for that reason resolved to say an encouraging word to the deeply bowed “speculation” [21] and keep the naughty “paradox” in check.

By no means, therefore, should one accuse Prof. Scharling of the presumption of wanting to level the differences in the conflicting views or, as it is called, to “mediate” speculation with the paradox; no, Prof. S. does not aim so high; he only thinks like this: each of the potencies can be good for itself, provided only that in mutual recognition they do not bother each other or hinder each other’s “fame”. To Prof. Scharling’s fame, then, let it be said that one should, according to his genial Apology, by no means take strict issue with opposite conceptions and heterogeneous principles, but on the contrary (p. 373) “one should contribute to the recognition and appreciation of every endeavor which, with enthusiasm for its goal and with modest acknowledgment of the powers granted for its attainment, aims at placing the truths on which the eternal and temporal welfare of individual human beings and of the whole human race depends in a clearer light, at grounding them more deeply, and in this way contributing to awaken and preserve reverence and devotion for their beneficent influence.”

That a fine feeling can also really underlie so genial an admonition must be admitted; these are childlike notions; but the difficulty is that such childlike notions prove nothing in a scientific discussion.

If, however, I asserted that nowhere in the whole genial Apology was any attempt made to clarify the scientific point of dispute, I would nevertheless go too far. There

is really one place where His Rev. bethinks himself that he really ought also to state
 [22] the problem; this place is found p. 367, and reads thus: "It is clear that the lever in the dialectic employed here is the straining of the concept: "*knowledge*," "*certainty*," "*coherent cognition*", to such a degree of "absoluteness" and "objectivity" that it either finds no application" etc.

So in the unreasonably exaggerated straining of the concept: "knowledge", "certainty", "coherent cognition", Prof. Scharling would see the "lever" with which an all too obtrusive dialectic has tried to lift "the Christian Dogmatics" off its speculative hinges. How it has come about that Prof. Scharling has caught sight of precisely this concept, and then believed that it was the lever, is not difficult to guess. When Prof. Martensen advanced with his great dogmatics, and wanted to make room to right and left, the concept "coherent cognition" was precisely the warning cry with which he signified to "the absolutes in faith" and "the absolutes in knowledge" that they now had to step aside, and not come too near him with their "stray thoughts and aphorisms, fancies and flashes." When I now in this crush was seized with fright, and was in anxiety at being pitifully run over, I grabbed for the "lever", and fortunately found it in "the paradox" in "Johannes Climacus". In order, however, to remind the reader of the veiled challenge that seemed to ring so bravely in the Martensenian slogan, I let the concept "coherent cognition" run along in my "examining review" as a little glaneur, so that in case the "lever" had its effect, no ear of the speculative load should be wasted. How, for the rest, I imagine I have used the "lever" is clear enough
 [23] from my last thesis: "*Christian dogmatics is without principle*". — That Prof. Scharling has not hit upon seeking the "lever" in this thesis certainly seems most strange, since the bar is otherwise palpable enough; but, as said, I greatly fear that His Rev. has his own opinions about what a principle is.

That I could in no way use the concept "coherent cognition" as a "lever", anyone will see who knows at all what a lever is. A lever must after all be firm and strong; but the concept "coherent cognition" is precisely a very soft and pliable concept that winds itself through all possible degrees. There are after all many kinds of coherence and many degrees in every coherence; there is real coherence, ideal coherence, firm coherence, loose coherence: everything, even the genial Apology, has its coherence; if Prof. Scharling therefore thinks he has found a bar in the category coherence, it can certainly not be a "lever"; it must then presumably be — another sort of bar; yet surely never a lime-rod!

As reward for his noble striving to boss "the paradox" about and keep order in

literature, Prof. Scharling expects that “the men against whose conduct he has now declared himself” will cool “their indignation in a philippic — whereby he foresees a treatment no less harsh than that which Marsyas experienced from the angered god.” — Alas! how strangely things go in this world with human foresight. I foresaw quite surely that I would get an answer from Prof. Martensen, and see, then I get — an Apology from Prof. Scharling; Prof. Scharling in turn foresees that he will get “a philippic” from me, and see, then he gets — a few genial words.

It is, by the way, strange enough that Prof. S. has been able to “foresee” that his genial Apology should really deserve a philippic, and thereby also foresee that [24] it would go with him as with Marsyas; this foresight must then surely also stem from one of the dark possibilities he sometimes sees when he sees the paradoxes in Pandora’s box. As far as I am concerned, His Rev. can truly rest assured that I shall never visit him with any philippic, or cool my indignation on an innocent man who surely will never arouse my indignation. In my writings I have never expressed any indignation against Prof. Scharling, never challenged Prof. Scharling, and, to put it plainly, seldom thought of Prof. Scharling. If Prof. S. will nonetheless kindly continue, as hitherto, to think of me, set me a little to rights and take care of my upbringing, I shall also know how to appreciate it in all quietness; only Prof. S. must not take it amiss if he only seldom sees written proof of my gratitude; I have, as said, a fear of engaging too much with Prof. Scharling, who always alarms me with his dark possibilities.

That the possibilities may be dark enough, I, who am not safe from any side, but only subsist by believing the best and fearing the worst, should least of all presume to deny. But even if the worst should happen, even if it should one day happen that either “the paradox” or “speculation” found itself entitled to endorse my servant’s testimonial, dismiss me as a useless servant, and pack me off — “nach Hause”; then I would nevertheless, as I am packed off “nach Hause”, quite gladly take along the consolation that “theological science” must at last have found its principle, and therewith also have preserved the conviction that Professor Scharling’s “spiritual nature constitutes a unity.”
